

Fritz Grabo

Senior Software Engineer & Consultant

St. Pölten, Austria
✉ hello@fritzgrabo.com
🌐 fritzgrabo.com
in fritzgrabo
🔗 fritzgrabo
Remote (EU/US East Coast time zones)



Professional Summary

Senior Full-Stack Engineer with 20+ years of experience, specializing in Ruby on Rails, sustainable system architecture, and engineering excellence. I build systems that scale, write code that lasts, and elevate teams through mentorship, collaboration and technical leadership. My approach combines deep technical expertise with strong business context, pragmatic problem-solving, and a "quality-first" mindset that has earned me the reputation of setting the standard others follow. Seeking remote Ruby/Rails engagements with quality-focused teams.

Key Highlights

- 2-month contract → 12-year core team member at US-based startup (2013 – 2025 acquisition)
- 15 years Ruby on Rails expertise; backend systems processing 90M+ annual transactions
- 12+ years proven remote collaboration across EU/US timezones with distributed teams
- "Do as the Austrians do" reputation for code quality and engineering practices
- Full-stack ownership: system architecture, implementation, DevOps, team mentoring

Core Competencies

Technical Skills

Backend	Ruby on Rails (15y), Ruby, PostgreSQL (advanced), FastAPI (3y), Python, MySQL
Frontend	Hotwire/Turbo/Stimulus (advocate), Vue.js, HTML5, CSS3
Infrastructure	GCP, Kubernetes, Docker, Terraform, Helm
Automation	CI/CD pipelines (GitHub Actions, GitLab CI); monitoring & alerting (Prometheus, Grafana)
Architecture	System design; API design; scaling distributed systems; tool-building mindset; data-driven decisions

Professional Strengths

Leadership	Technical decision-making; architecture ownership; mentoring engineers
Collaboration	Remote-first, cross-functional practices; requirements engineering; stakeholder management
Delivery	Pragmatic problem-solving; reliable execution on critical projects; quality-focused craftsmanship

Professional Experience

- 2013 – 2025 **Senior Software Engineer**, Opro (acquired by Blue Yonder, 2025), Washington DC, USA
Reverse logistics and returns management platform serving major retailers (GAP, BestBuy, etc.). Accompanied company journey from early startup phase through substantial growth to successful acquisition, gaining deep experience in system design, service architecture, and scaling technical infrastructure.
- **Earned 12-year core team position after exceptional 2-month contract delivery.** Built “do as the Austrians do” reputation for technical excellence; key contributor to customer-facing platforms (Blinq.com, Bulq.com), in-store returns management apps for IKEA, GAP, and warehouse operations systems; enabled integrations with numerous clients and 3rd party services; maintained system stability during peak-traffic periods (Black Friday traffic spikes)
 - **Owned architecture and technical decisions with future-focused problem solving:** “I can always rely on Fritz to research a problem and provide several solutions we can take to address them” (Sr. Staff Engineer); planned and executed technical projects independently and cross-functionally; backend systems processed 90M+ transactions annually; demonstrated ability to consider future needs when addressing current problems
 - **Delivered full-stack solutions from system architecture to production:** Colleagues describe work as showing “attention to detail, thoughtful preparation, and deep understanding of both technical and business context”; excelled across frontend, backend, and infrastructure development; reduced technical debt through systematic refactoring while maintaining feature velocity

- **Elevated team capabilities through mentoring and code review excellence:** “Turns the code review process into a positive and collaborative learning experience for everyone involved” (Staff Engineer); mentored junior and mid-level engineers through pair programming and thoughtful reviews; established practices adopted across engineering teams; earned reputation for “rare combination of curiosity and empathy”
- **Maximized remote productivity with exceptional async execution:** EU timezone enabled deep focus work where US colleagues would “notify [Fritz] of a new, urgent task, only to wake up the next morning to find it completely resolved”; maintained consistent half-day overlap for collaboration; strong cross-timezone communication through detailed documentation
- **Owned DevOps lifecycle for team services:** Created Helm charts, configured CI/CD pipelines (GitHub, GitLab), implemented comprehensive monitoring/alerting (Prometheus, Grafana, GCP); operated with high degree of ownership and integrity across all deployments
- **Contributed to major technology transitions:** Participated in monolith-to-services migration, on-premise to cloud infrastructure shift (Kubernetes to GCP), Rails-to-Python language migration; consistently raised the bar in way that leveled up engineering teams

2010 – 2013 **Self-Employed Software Engineer & Consultant**, Various Clients, Austria

Founded independent practice focused on Ruby on Rails development, serving diverse clients from startups to enterprise. Early Rails adopter (v3, 2011) after transitioning from Java/Spring background.

- **Delivered production-grade applications across multiple industries:** Time tracking system for NÖMedia (still running 15+ years later), registration platform for Henkel management events, exhibition software for Antiloop/DMG Mori Seiki, psychotherapy/coaching marketplace connecting practitioners with clients. Managed full project lifecycle including client communication, technical scoping, and long-term maintenance
- **Built collaborative network of specialist engineers:** Established partnerships based on transparency and shared ownership; long-term collaboration with Wolfgang Rittner later became foundation for “Team Austria” remote team at Optoro. Approach emphasized quality delivery and lasting client relationships over transactional project work

2004 – 2008 **Software Engineer**, *artindustrial it GmbH*, Vienna, Austria

First professional role after university. Enterprise web application development using Java, JEE, and Spring.

- **Built enterprise web solutions for major Austrian organizations:** Intersport Austria e-commerce platform, Ärztekammer Niederösterreich (medical association) portal, ÖQMed nationwide quality assurance system for Austrian healthcare sector. Gained foundation in full-stack development, client communication, and building scalable systems for demanding production environments

Additional Experience

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|---------------------|---|
| Corporate Training | git-training.at (2014-present) — Provide Git migration and adoption training for enterprises including Qualcomm (Austria; United Kingdom), Schneider Electric, STIWA, IBS, Therefore, etc. |
| Leadership | NGO Mit Kindern wachsen (2024-present) — Steering committee member; operating a private school for 100 students; implementing projects related to education and personal development. |
| Social Impact | NGO ICT4D.at (2008-2016) — 3-month teaching engagement on-ground in Tanzania providing web development education to underprivileged youth; additional engagement on-ground in Mozambique. |
| University Teaching | FH St. Pölten (2004-2010, part-time) — Taught programming (130+ students, Java) and advanced web development (Master’s level); supervised Bachelor’s and Master’s theses; highest student evaluation scores in program multiple times. |

Education

2000 – 2004 **Diplom-Ingenieur (FH), Telekommunikation und Medientechnik**, *University of Applied Sciences St. Pölten*, Austria, *Graduated with Distinction*

Open Source & Community

Open Source: Active Emacs ecosystem contributor; author of several packages and contributor to numerous community projects (github.com/fritzgrabo)